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A radical freedom? Gianni Vattimo's 'emancipatory nihilism'

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Abstract What scope is there for emancipatory politics in light of the post-modern critique of philosophical foundations? This paper examines the response to this question by Italian philosopher, Gianni Vattimo, who for over two decades has defended the emancipatory prospects of what he terms 'nihilism'. Vattimo conceives the retreat of metaphysics as a progressive weakening of ontological claims and an opening towards new and diverse modes of being. In his view, far from an exclusively tragic experience of loss or meaninglessness, nihilism is a steadily expanding narrative that invites us to face up to our own radical freedom. The paper sets out Vattimo's central arguments and contrasts the ethical thrust of his 'emancipatory nihilism' with the distinctly political take on emancipation presented by Ernesto Laclau. While the two converge on the withdrawal of metaphysics as the premise for a radical and democratic freedom, Vattimo's vision remains insufficiently focused on the dynamics of contestation that a generalized nihilism implies.

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Introduction

What are the implications for emancipatory politics of the critique of foundational thought? There are, of course, many possible answers to this question. Some embrace the critique as a liberation from sovereign claims to 'knowledge' and 'truth', hoping to subvert the dominant cultural norms of liberal societies. Others, no less wary of submitting to such claims, remain sceptical that liberation yields wholly positive results and prefer instead to entrust our hopes to an ungrounded but generally beneficial liberal-democratic *modus vivendi*, rather than openly challenge its cultural foundations. The first approach has been the libertarian impulse of postmodern radicals, exemplified



by figures such as Foucault or Derrida, who invite a politics of desire and an expanded 'play' of difference. The second approach not only has a progressive advocate in the late Richard Rorty, but also a more pessimistic proponent in John Gray who foresees increasing conflict and uncertainty as once-established norms weaken.¹

At stake in these contrasting views is the question of how to respond to the notion of 'radical freedom': that is, a freedom that is neither the 'negative' right to act without interference nor a 'positive' freedom to fulfil certain, shared human capacities, but something deeper.² Radical freedom implies the intrinsic malleability of the social world, its infinite openness to alteration and innovation beyond the narrow horizons of liberal individualism. As Jean-Luc Nancy (1993, pp. 3–8) argues, freedom is commonly thought in terms of subjectivity, that is, as the freedom of an already-constituted subject or 'self', be it an individual or a community. If, by contrast, freedom 'designates nothing more and nothing less than existence itself' (1993, p. 14), that is, the very openness of subjects to 'be' otherwise, then what kind of emancipatory politics might ensue? At first glance, neither of the above options seems wholly satisfactory. One side advocates radical freedom as an opportunity for 'heroic' acts of aesthetic self-cultivation, but this appears to restrict any genuinely collective enterprise. The others tend to justify a moderate, even conservative, containment of the possible 'excesses' of freedom within established social and cultural structures. How, then, might radical freedom be conjoined to an inclusive yet still emancipatory project?

In this paper I examine the work of a thinker, largely undiscussed in Anglophone debates, who promotes an emancipatory project based on post-foundational premises without, however, succumbing either to an aesthetic individualism, to complacent liberal democracy or to anti-utopian pessimism: the Italian philosopher, Gianni Vattimo. In advocating what he calls 'Emancipatory Nihilism', Vattimo foregrounds a 'hermeneutic' ontology, that is, a politics of interpretation and dialogue premised on radical freedom. Drawing on the works of Nietzsche, Heidegger and Gadamer, Vattimo premises his argument on a conception of the 'weakening' of Being in late modernity. In this respect, 'nihilism' denotes a generalized condition in which foundations are progressively dissolved, opening up opportunities to modify and contest norms and values and to explore new ways of being. Nihilism, then, is conceived as an experience that radically disrupts accepted norms and values but that is also inescapably collective. It invites us not to renounce all norms in favour of individual self-creation but, rather, to respond generously to their ongoing decline across a range of experiences. As we shall see, what is at work here can be described as a Heideggerian notion of 'disclosive' freedom, a libertarian injunction to 'let beings be', rather than freedom as a form of 'mastery' over ourselves or others.



After sketching the philosophical arguments that underpin Vattimo's thought, I outline some of the distinctive features of Emancipatory Nihilism conceived as a justification for a democratic pluralism. Finally, I evaluate Vattimo's arguments in light of a similar post-foundational philosophy, that of Ernesto Laclau. Laclau's theorization of emancipation shares many of Vattimo's premises but stresses the strategic and political rather than the ethical dimension of a project supporting radical freedom. This comparison serves to raise questions about the capacity of Emancipatory Nihilism, as currently articulated, to translate a philosophy of radical freedom into a coherent emancipatory politics.

'Weak Thought': Towards a Hermeneutic Ontology

Vattimo first came to prominence outside of Italy in the 1980s with a co-edited collection of essays, *Il pensiero debole* (Weak Thought) (see Vattimo and Rovatti, 1983). Gathering together a number of leading Italian 'postmodern' philosophers, the collection embraced the so-called 'weakening' of ontology in light of the critique of metaphysics announced by Nietzsche's claim that 'God is dead'. Taking seriously Nietzsche's assertion, argued the editors, meant accepting that a 'single, ultimate normative foundation cannot be given' (Rovatti and Vattimo, 1983, p. 7). Claims to 'truth' should no longer expect to be grounded 'objectively' on the basis of fully agreed, or 'strong', principles of reason. It was therefore no longer possible to treat social criticism as a form of 'unmasking' the reality disguised 'behind' forms of power and domination. Nor, however, was it possible simply to renounce metaphysics in favour of some new kind of truth. Instead, philosophers were increasingly adopting a weakened ontology receptive to the way truth and being were mediated by language. *Weak Thought* was therefore a generalized 'slogan' or 'attitude' announcing the withdrawal from, rather than refutation of, metaphysical certainty (Rovatti and Vattimo, 1983, pp. 9–11). This characterization of postmodern philosophy became emblematic of Vattimo's general philosophical outlook and, as we will see below, was essential in his interpretation of late modernity in terms of what he called a 'hermeneutic ontology' and 'nihilism'.

In his own contribution to the collection, Vattimo substantiated what he regarded as the principal themes of *Weak Thought* by way of a contrast with the notion of 'dialectics', a key term, at the time, in Marxist theory. Dialectical thought, he argued, is built around two fundamental notions: 'totality' and 'reappropriation'. True knowledge, accordingly, is knowledge of the whole, or the totality. The achievement of such knowledge permits the reappropriation of totality by a social agent. This is precisely the logic behind Marxism's critique of ideology: limited social agents are unable to grasp the whole because of the



distorting and mystifying effects of bourgeois ideology. A revolutionary class (or its party), however, succeeds in reappropriating the totality by becoming aware of its revolutionary function and conjoining theory and practice in revolutionary action (Vattimo, 1983, pp. 13–14).

For Vattimo, following Heidegger, this dialectical conception was premised on a metaphysical account of truth that sought the correspondence of thought with a stable, eternally ‘present’ structure of reality. But, as Marxists themselves discovered, the point of view of totality easily becomes a tool of domination in the hands of those who claim to have appropriated it (1983, p. 17). The genuinely critical task for Heidegger, therefore, was to renounce the metaphysics of presence and seek out a deeper, non-metaphysical understanding of truth. This he sought to do with his conception of ‘ontological difference’ (see Heidegger, 1969) – the difference between beings, such as humans, and Being as such (signified here with a capital).

For Heidegger, Being is understood as an ‘event’, an opening to the world and its possibilities into which beings are ‘thrown’ (see Heidegger, 1962). Human existence is not reducible to any specific kind of entity – such as nature – knowledge of which might serve as a stable ‘ground’ for establishing its ‘proper’ features. Rather, human existence is, fundamentally, a projection that is always ahead of itself, always acting and thinking in light of a future that is never fully attained. Being, as possibility, emerges out of nothing. What things ‘are’ is revealed in a process of ‘unconcealment’ whereby form, value and function are attributed to things, casting light on them in distinctive ways, but also holding back other possibilities in the dark. Human existence is fundamentally temporal, or finite, always facing the prospect of death. Never static and complete but – because death is the purest form of future possibility, one we never actually experience but constantly look towards – existence is essentially open and incomplete (Vattimo, 2005, pp. 45–55. See also De Beistegui, 2005, pp. 44–46).

For Heidegger, further, western metaphysics has caused us to ‘forget’ our relationship to Being. Metaphysics treats Being as though it were a fully present entity of which we can have direct knowledge, rather than as an opening towards the future. Having surrendered our capacity to reflect on Being we have, instead, objectified it and, in the modern age, subordinated ourselves to domination by technology. This, he claims, is our ‘fallen’ condition, our sense of ‘homelessness’ and marks the ‘oblivion of being’ (Heidegger, 1993, 1998a, pp. 258–259). But instead of the truths of science and technology, Heidegger argues we need to revive a deeper, ontological sense of truth, one that serves not as a ‘ground’ to scientific knowledge but as the spur to greater existential awareness. If there is a ground to human existence at all, it is, he says, an ‘abyssal ground’, one whose very absence presents a permanent ‘potentiality for being’ (Heidegger, 1998b, p. 134).



For Vattimo, Heidegger's conception of Being as an event refuses all metaphysical certainties.³ This is a 'weakening' rather than a 'refutation' (which would be in the name of another truth based on a new ground), a 'declension' (*declinazione*) from the quest for absolute certainty rather than its substitution by another principle. Vattimo uses Heidegger's term *Verwindung* to denote the way a non-metaphysical approach to Being invites a 'working through' of our philosophical inheritance (Vattimo, 1983, p. 21). Heidegger deliberately employs this term instead of *Überwindung* ('overcoming') in order to stress the withdrawal from, rather than utter rejection of, metaphysics, and to rethink the truth of our Being as an historical and cultural legacy, an opening to certain possibilities handed down to us, not an objective fact or principle to be 'discovered' once and for all.

Weak Thought, argued Vattimo, tasks philosophy with a new and distinctive purpose: 'the thinking of truth is not the thinking that "founds", as metaphysics thinks, even in its Kantian version; rather, it is that which, by demonstrating fallenness [*caducità*] and mortality as precisely that which makes Being, undertakes an unfounding' (1983, p. 23). Weak Thought therefore adopts a critical outlook, underscoring the contingency of truth claims, their validity in what he calls a 'rhetorical' rather than purely logical conceptual horizon (1983, p. 26). Asking himself whether such a position implies passively accepting the world as it is, Vattimo responds in the negative. If a weakened ontology renounces the quest for origins and projects, such as those of Marxism, which seek to refound social order, nevertheless it is not bound to a conservative quietism. On the contrary, withdrawing from the quest for certainty permits us to explore the alternative truths that our inherited traditions have excluded. Our cultural traditions are not unitary but diverse, hence weakening them opens up the opportunity to explore new worlds, not as replacement truths but as 'interferences' and 'distortions' of the traditions we have inherited (1983, p. 26–28). For instance, ethnic or sexual identities are difficult simply to renounce even if understood as essentially arbitrary 'social' constructions. A weakened ontology implores us to explore the variations that distort and diversify such identities, rather than dispose of them altogether.

Throughout the 1980s and 1990s, Vattimo championed the, then, cutting-edge positions elaborated in this paper. Nowadays, the claims of Weak Thought might be understood as one variant of a wider species of argument. That is, the view – expressed in various ways by numerous authors such as Lyotard, Derrida, Rorty, Foucault and others – that the age of 'grand narratives' based on a search for 'ultimate' intellectual foundations is over and that this inaugurates a new era called the 'postmodern' (see, for example, Lyotard, 1984; Rorty, 1989; White, 2000). In this new era, the presumption of a single 'reality' has given way to a more 'relativistic' condition in which the



ambitions of the Enlightenment are replaced by a greater appreciation of language, culture and difference in the constitution of reality.

This is certainly a valid generalization of postmodernism and of Weak Thought's place within it. But it obscures some of the specificities of Vattimo's enterprise. Unlike the predominantly French strain of postmodern thought, Vattimo's route to the critique of foundationalism was neither through structuralism nor, specifically, the linguistics of Ferdinand de Saussure, which lent a distinctively semiotic and textual twist to the argument. Rather, Vattimo's trajectory has been primarily via scholarly engagements with Heidegger and Nietzsche. As a consequence, his stress has been on aspects of the latter's work, in particular the characterization of Being in a 'post-metaphysical' epoch (see, in particular, Vattimo, 1988a, 1993). Although he has been keen to underscore continuities and overlaps with, for example, Derrida's project of 'deconstruction',⁴ Vattimo's elaboration of Weak Thought emphasized our general relation to the postmodern condition and the kinds of judgement we can legitimately mobilize therein.

There are two aspects of Vattimo's approach to be noted here: the characterization of modernity in terms of 'secularization' and 'nihilism', and his insistence on the necessarily 'hermeneutic grounding' of Being in a nihilistic age. Both aspects were formulated in relation to the writings of Nietzsche and Heidegger and are central to his approach to emancipation. I shall outline them below.

Vattimo's take on modernity draws from Heidegger's claim that western thought is now at the end of its metaphysical 'adventure'. Yet, if Heidegger had once seemed virulently opposed to metaphysics, in his later work he came to view metaphysical thought as an unavoidable dimension of the western experience. Metaphysics could not be discarded like some unwanted garment: it was part of who we have become. Instead, it was necessary to withdraw from it by carefully returning to its dominant motifs in order to think them in new ways. For Vattimo, it is this combined decline of metaphysics with the steady interrogation of, and withdrawal from, its grasp that characterizes the end of modernity and the promise of postmodernity (see Vattimo, 1988a). Although metaphysics is often the basis of forms of violence, we cannot renounce it in favour of a new truth (for instance, of the absence of metaphysical certainty) without once more subjecting others and ourselves to the possibility of more violence. The God of metaphysics cannot be replaced by a new God, the western *logos* with a new *logos*. For Vattimo, taking leave of metaphysics is better understood as a process akin to secularization (see Vattimo, 1988b). The historical secularization of Christian civilization – itself a reconstitution of the Greek *logos* – involved not only a weakening of biblical certainty, but also a vigorous return to its meanings and sources to interrogate the inheritance. Likewise, grasping Being as an event that constitutes us involves returning to



the various principles of metaphysics in order to liberate them from their more violent connotations (Vattimo, 1988b, pp. 59–61).

This characterization of late modernity feeds into the experience of 'nihilism'. This term, taken from Nietzsche, is typically understood in a negative sense, as a loss of ultimate meaning and certainty. However, for Vattimo its true potential lies in the 'active' rather than 'passive' sense of the term whereby we refuse to resign ourselves to a feeling of loss but, instead, grasp this loss as an opportunity to conceive ourselves as creators of new values (Vattimo, 2006). Nietzsche's definition of nihilism as the loss of the 'highest values' is not a rejection of truth as such, it is only a reject of the elevation of truth to the status of an absolute. Moreover, the loss is not some aberration brought to the West from the outside. It is a consequence of the very pursuit of scientific truth itself. Having taken over the search for an incontestable foundation handed to it by Christianity (and, before that, Greek metaphysics), Enlightenment reason came to contest its own foundations, rejecting both God and also, later, the principles of scientific validity.

Thus nihilism defines a passage *through* western metaphysics, not merely its renunciation. For Nietzsche, it was only by facing the full consequences of nihilism that a new kind of humanity – designated by the idea of the 'overman' – might emerge. When read through Heidegger's emphasis on Being, nihilism becomes the bracing experience not only of losing faith in our ultimate values, but also of having necessarily to endure this experience. Nihilism is not something we can choose to avoid because it is part of the very story of metaphysics we have inherited. Our nihilistic condition is what constitutes our Being in the late modern era.

It is in respect of this nihilistic experience that Vattimo seeks an alternative, positive narrative. As metaphysics is not something we can renounce but to which we are, instead, destined to return perpetually, if only to 'take our leave' of its stronger motifs, the kind of grounding appropriate to this nihilistic age is, in his view, a hermeneutical one. The 'real world', as Nietzsche argued, has become a fable or 'myth' (see Nietzsche, 1968, pp. 50–51). No longer can we rely on the assumption of thought's progressive approximation to the fundamental principles of the universe. We are unable, he asserted, to rise above language and metaphor to gain an unmediated access to the 'real world'. Fundamentally, reality is a fiction dependant upon the grammar of enquiry of western thought. For Vattimo, drawing on Gadamer, this points us towards the ultimately *interpretive* nature of truth, that is, its 'hermeneutic' basis in received traditions of interpretation.

Vattimo warns against treating hermeneutics as a 'generic philosophy of culture' that emphasizes merely the historical contingency of truth (see Vattimo, 1997, pp.1–6). Such a view permits the return of a metaphysical



orientation by implying that interpretation can itself be mastered through 'objective' study, becoming a 'purely relativistic philosophy of cultural multiplicity' (1997, p. 9). Hermeneutics is more than just a sense of historicity; it is a 'philosophy of modernity', a 'narrative' bound to the experience of nihilism. Awareness of the interpretive nature of truth is simultaneously awareness of who we are in late-modernity as post-metaphysical beings. A hermeneutical grounding, properly conceived, is an invitation to grasp the present in terms of the weakening of Being. Far from providing a sense of superiority, casting our critical interpretive gaze across the assumed truths of the world, hermeneutics encourages us to face up to our nihilistic vocation in all areas of life, from science and art through to ethics and religion. Thus he points to 'the generalization of the notion of interpretation to the point where it coincides with the very experience of the world' (1997, p. 4). Hermeneutics, he argues, is fast becoming a *koiné*, a common idiom, in so many spheres, not least as a consequence of the heavily mediated world of interpretations we inhabit (on which, see Vattimo, 1992). It cannot, however, be reduced to an automatic consequence of social or technological changes. Rather, hermeneutics is itself an interpretation of the world that responds, differently in each domain, to the 'calling' of the historical experience of nihilism, the epochal decline of metaphysical truth (Vattimo, 1997, p. 8).

Nihilism and Emancipation: A Postmodern Public Philosophy

Like other postmodern philosophers, Vattimo originally shared in the anticipation of a progressive liberation from social and cultural hierarchies in the wake of the revolts of 1968. Movements such as feminism and, particularly, gay liberation form the broad backdrop to his theoretical enquiries. The heightened possibilities for greater personal freedom were explicit, for instance, in his early reading of Nietzsche's idea of the overman (see Vattimo, 2007b). However, from the mid-1970s onwards, Vattimo has offered up a more nuanced reading of emancipation in response to what he regarded as the excesses of left-wing struggles. These, he felt, tended to mistake emancipation from socio-cultural hierarchies for a *total* freedom of self-creation. But this was to reintroduce a metaphysics of the will, which assumed mankind was essentially free to discard any and all values. As he put it in an interview of 1980 with the newspaper of the far-left party, *Lotta Continua*, his early work on Nietzsche had been 'too bewitched by the dialectic', understanding liberation in terms of 'conciliation, reappropriation of oneself, and therefore (even if only implicitly) in terms of self-consciousness' (Vattimo, 1984, pp. 21–22).



Vattimo's defence of Weak Thought in the 1980s and, more recently, his concerted advocacy of nihilism presents a revised and nuanced affirmation of emancipation. Nihilism offers a horizon against which a diverse plurality of socio-political demands can be legitimized without endorsing the transcendence of liberal democratic principles. In his work of the past three decades, Vattimo has aimed to demonstrate how Emancipatory Nihilism translates radical freedom into a collective, democratic ethic. His endorsement of diversity operates within an interpretation of a common epochal transformation of Being that mitigates the effect of radically renouncing metaphysics, drawing it away from a politics of pure alterity or individualized self-cultivation and towards a non-revolutionary, or 'social democratic', libertarianism (see Rorty, 2007).⁵

Before we consider how Vattimo has presented this argument, it will help to clarify the concept of radical freedom that informs it. Emancipation implies a liberation, a releasing of subjects to a freedom from certain restrictions. But to what kind of freedom? Although he has not pursued a rigorous exploration of his philosophy in relation to political theory, we can understand the concept of freedom at work here as 'disclosive' in a Heideggerian sense. This concept is argued by Leslie Paul Thiele (see Thiele, 1994, 1995) to involve a distinctive sense of freedom premised on an awareness of our ontological constitution. Unlike other, 'practical' concepts of freedom, Heidegger's is not built around the notion of mastery, whether of one's own private domain secure from interference (the negative concept) or of one's 'higher' self (the positive concept). For Heidegger, we are fundamentally free in the sense that, as beings projected towards a future, we participate in the ongoing disclosure of our world, the revealing of its parameters and possibilities (see Heidegger, 2005). Here freedom is irreducible to subjective choice; it denotes our formation as subjects by entrance into an 'open region' of possibilities. We share in our own constitution from 'nothing', its illumination from the shadows into a world of significance and 'truth'. The essence of this truth, argued Heidegger, is freedom itself: 'Freedom for what is opened up in an open region lets beings be the beings they are. Freedom now reveals itself as letting beings be' (Heidegger, 1998c, p. 144). This is not the freedom of a subject to command or master the world, but an originary freedom that precedes our sense of self and desire and discloses the world as such.

In various ways, Heidegger argued, we should adopt a more 'resolute' or 'anticipatory' disposition to the ways we constitute, or disclose, our world. That is, by dispensing with our passive acceptance of circumstances via received opinion or their reduction to forces of nature, and by acknowledging their inexhaustible, sometimes hidden, often mysterious, possibility to be otherwise, we might learn to dwell in the world more resolutely than we do. We might, then, become the 'guardians' or the 'shepherds' of



Being and not its 'masters', valuing our freedom as co-instigators of our own futures (Thiele, 1994, pp. 282–283). As Thiele points out, despite Heidegger's own devastating political choices, his philosophical approach to freedom does not direct us to any particular social and political arrangements (1994, p. 284) and could be developed in various ways. These might include, for example, a more cautious approach to the environment and our exploitation of its resources, or a withdrawal from the dogmatic prescriptions of gender identity in favour of a more complex appreciation of sexual difference (see Thiele, 1995, Chapters 4–9). A disclosive freedom is 'political' because, however it is undertaken, it enjoins us to exercise a concern over a shared world and to be mindful of its possibilities. Here freedom is not a property of the will but a freedom to 'let beings be'. Despite appearances that phrase implies an active engagement, a thoughtful questioning of a world that always exceeds our total control (Thiele, 1995, pp. 82–83). The world and its inhabitants are not instruments to shore up our autonomy or to meet some preconceived designs. Disclosive freedom is not an unbounded licence simply to do as we choose or act without constraint. Rather, it is an injunction to avoid the imposition of a metaphysical dogma (defining the world and its inhabitants as mere objects of our will) and to be attentive to the destructiveness brought by our desire to control, whether in the realm of scientific inquiry, sexual norms or management of the environment.

Although Vattimo does not directly discuss Heidegger's concept of freedom, Emancipatory Nihilism can be understood as generally in tune with it. As Vattimo himself insists, he is not promoting the replacement of a condition of alienation with one of self-mastery. Rather, he regards emancipatory demands as opportunities to explore different ways of being which, like linguistic dialects and local cultures, distort the dominant metaphysical languages we inherit from past traditions.

The emancipatory effect of the liberation of local rationalities is not confined to guaranteeing everyone the possibility of greater recognition and 'authenticity', as if emancipation meant finally showing what everyone – black, woman, homosexual, Protestant, etc. – 'really' is [...]. The emancipatory significance of the liberation of differences and dialects consists rather in the general disorientation accompanying their initial identification. If in a world of dialects, I speak my own dialect, I shall be conscious that it is not the only 'language', but that it is precisely one amongst many. If in this multicultural world, I set out my system of religious, aesthetic, political and ethnic values, I shall be acutely conscious of the historicity, contingency and finiteness of these systems, starting with my own. (Vattimo, 1992, p. 9)



Liberation, then, is not the achievement of mastery but the release to a sometimes disorienting sense of contingency that comes from facing our own finitude. 'To live in this pluralistic world means to experience freedom as a continual oscillation between belonging and disorientation' (1992, p. 10). Although he does not rule out some element of mastery as part of an emancipatory politics – and hence he supports negative rights and even some positive, minimal conditions for human flourishing – Vattimo's accent, like Heidegger's, is on exposing ourselves to the often 'problematic' and discomforting experience that the truths we live by (concerning social identities or the sources of authority, for example) are not reflections of a stable and incontestable reality but interpretations shared with others (but not everyone). Emancipatory Nihilism is, for Vattimo, the medium of this exposure and it therefore shares in Heidegger's disclosive sense of freedom.

We can see this disclosive orientation extrapolated further in two key themes of his recent book, *Nihilism and Emancipation* (2003): namely, his reference to an 'ethics of finitude' and his defence of procedural democracy. In the first, Vattimo defends what he also calls a 'postmetaphysical ethics' or 'ethics of finitude' as a sensibility in tune with late modernity (Vattimo, 2003, p. 64). As we have noted, for him, this historical moment is characterized by the progressive dissolution of foundational principles and the subsequent pluralization of interpretations. In an increasingly technological society, particularly one dominated by the mass media which persistently manipulates and fragments experience, this process has accelerated out of all control (see Vattimo, 1992). For Vattimo, our nihilistic condition generates an ethical space within which we are confronted with our finitude. Pain, he argues, 'is the very essence of metaphysics' and its 'only one limit ... is solidarity with others, the assumption of our own finitude' (2003, pp. 71, 77; see also 1997, pp. 28–29).

Vattimo's understanding of ethics is not built upon any rigid moral principle but entails 'a critical stance vis-à-vis everything that is put forward as an ultimate and universal principle' (2003, p. 42). This is not a renunciation of moral principles as such. We all reason from 'truths' we feel to be intrinsically right. But, if we accept that such truths are weakening, then we are compelled to acknowledge other interpretations. Here Vattimo rejects both Rorty and Derrida when they 'urge us not to speak any longer of Being':

simply to affirm that there exist many different visions of the world in the style of Rorty, or to review and deconstruct them in the style of Derrida, seems not to take sufficiently seriously the fact that the manifold visions of the world do not peacefully coexist like a collection of artistic styles and lifestyles in an imaginary museum. They give rise to conflicts, claims of validity, and assertions of belonging, and philosophy is



expected to supply some indication of rational criteria to keep these differences from degenerating into outright wars between cultures. (2003, p. 28)

The end of metaphysics gives rise to ‘conflicts of interpretation’ that demand we return more thoughtfully to our principles and engage in dialogue; hence the primacy Vattimo gives to hermeneutics as the ground of ethics. Hermeneutics, as we have noted, is not simply the view that ‘everything is an interpretation’. It compels us to acknowledge ‘the situation to which we really belong before all else, and towards which we are responsible in our ethical choices ... [namely] the dissolution of principles, of nihilism’ (2003, p. 41). In contrast to Rorty’s sanguine pluralism or poststructuralism’s dispossession of metaphysical hierarchies, Vattimo underscores the imperative of philosophy to develop a common narrative, ironically just as ‘grand narratives’ are in decline.

By defining our epochal ‘situation’, nihilism prevents a postmetaphysical ethics collapsing into pure relativism. It serves as a thin thread unifying a wide variety of experiences. As a principle – an interpretation, not an ‘objective truth’ – guiding us to explore our values and identities as traditions that we inherit and ‘distort’, nihilism can only orient us towards our situation; it cannot be employed without contradiction to forcibly constrain our behaviour. For Vattimo, however, it is sufficient to rule out the possibility of violence based on claims to ‘first principles’ and to promote ‘peace and liberty’, and ‘respect for the other’ (2003, pp. 46–47, 58).

There is no teleology here that determines we dialogue more, or in any specific way. The nature of dialogue depends on the ‘vicissitudes’ of modern life, the problems and issues thrown up by it; it is not predetermined in any way as part of the development of society (2003, pp. 94–95). Indeed, Vattimo seems conscious that alternative ways of dealing with the dissolution of foundations and pluralization of interpretations are available: the return to an absolutizing foundationalism in religious fundamentalism, the marketization of pluralism by neo-liberals or the ‘communitarian’ withdrawal into smaller ‘ethnic’ communities. But these fail fully to explore (and sometimes they simply refuse to acknowledge) the wider horizon of a nihilistic age. Instead, Vattimo invites a more ironic response that encourages us to dilute our interpretations and weaken our sense of objective self-certainty in the manner of Nietzsche’s overman (2003, pp. 56–57).

Vattimo therefore regards democracy as the proper counterpart to an ethics of finitude: ‘the end of metaphysics has its genuine political parallel in the strengthening of democracy’ (2003, p. 83). He underscores the importance of a ‘procedural’ rather than a ‘substantive’ concept of democracy, rejecting any idea that a substantial community of interests, transparent to itself, pre-exists the play of interpretations and the formation of consensus. Although he



endorses the proceduralism of thinkers such as Habermas, Vattimo rejects as 'philosophically unacceptable' his preference for grounding communication in universal, rational principles (2003, p. 157; see also 1992, pp. 105–120). Such a desire, in Vattimo's view, threatens to legitimize an authoritarian linkage of politics and philosophy, with an impossible and disabling hunt for 'interests' that might interfere with 'transparent' dialogue. There never can be a total transparency, he argues, as all interpretations are finite and bound up with distinctive ways of being in the world. Proceduralism must therefore 'free itself of the metaphysical residues it still contains' if, like hermeneutics, it is to enable the conflict of interpretations to unfold (2003, p. 161).

Although he has always held an 'ethico-political' orientation (see Flores d'Arcais, 2007), Vattimo's reflections on political theory are relatively thin; suggestive interventions rather than substantial elaborations. Instead, he has offered up Emancipatory Nihilism in what might be called a form of postmodern 'public philosophy' by combining his role as academic at the University of Turin with a more civically engaged profile. In this he is not dissimilar to Rorty (see Rorty, 1999). Vattimo's contributions to questions of ethics and politics in the last few decades have been via debates on the Left and in regular columns in Italian newspapers and magazines. Like other philosophers in continental Europe, Vattimo's discourse has often been directed towards an educated but non-philosophical public. His defence of Emancipatory Nihilism therefore has the quality of a generalized understanding of the epoch against which specific issues are illuminated, rather than an elaborate or technical theory. Thus has he championed the rights of minorities, especially the gay community in Italy, and defended the role of the European Union in ensuring social democratic rights to equality and liberty. For many years, Vattimo was a member of the libertarian Radical Party in Italy. In the 1990s he joined the centre-left party, the 'post-communist' Democrats of the Left and was elected Member of the European Parliament between 1992 and 2004. Recently, Vattimo parted company with the Democrats of the Left, resisting what he sees as its acceptance of the market and narrow electoral pragmatism, and has joined forces with the far left communists (see Vattimo, 2007a, pp. 30–35).⁶ Despite the instability in his personal political alignments over the years, however, Vattimo's argument has remained broadly consistent: to underscore the possibility for liberation from dogmatism and authoritarian social and political arrangements in light of the declining legitimacy of the metaphysical arguments that support them.

A Politics of Emancipation?

Vattimo's approach to emancipation is comparable in many respects to other 'post-foundational' philosophers of the Left (see White, 2000; Marchart, 2007).



Ernesto Laclau is one thinker who has also defended the promise of emancipation for a plurality of groups and movements in light of the critique of metaphysics. As a leading exponent of a radical democratic ‘post-marxism’, he shares many presuppositions with Vattimo – including the exhaustion of metaphysics and grand narratives, the ontological significance of language, radical freedom, the absence of a privileged or unitary subject, and so forth – but his approach nevertheless stresses the political rather than ethical moment, that is, the way emancipatory discourses entail both inclusion *and* exclusion, and hence an unavoidable element of contest. Although there is considerable sympathy between the two approaches, Laclau’s work exposes some of the difficulties of Vattimo’s Emancipatory Nihilism. Let us consider what Laclau has to say.

In his book *Emancipation(s)* (1996), Laclau draws attention to two key dimensions of classic emancipatory discourses: the dimensions of ‘dichotomy’ and ‘ground’ (Laclau, 1996, pp. 1–2). The dichotomic dimension refers to the radical division between emancipation and the previous order. Without this division, struggles for liberation would be unable to signify the discontinuity implied by a break with oppression: emancipation involves an ‘absolute chasm’, or antagonism, between the new and old situation. The dimension of ground, on the other hand, refers to the depth to which the rupture penetrates the social field. A radical act of emancipation must have effects across society, leaving no part untouched. But, for Laclau, although co-present, the two dimensions cannot be logically reconciled. The dichotomic dimension involves a fundamental rejection of the previous order such that no common measure with it can be admitted. But this is incompatible with the dimension of ground that identifies an objective social basis upon which a comparison can be made. If the break between one (emancipated) order and another (oppressive order) is to be genuine, argues Laclau, it cannot be explained by reference to a common ground: ‘There would be no break, no true emancipation if the act constitutive of the latter was only the result of the internal differentiation of the oppressing system’ (Laclau, 1996, p. 3).

In other words, ‘society’ cannot be understood as transparently the same object if the break is truly radical, at least not without distorting the sense of a decisive break. When the dimension of ground dominates in emancipatory discourse, the point of rupture is reduced to an internal moment in the unfolding of a structural logic (for example, the myth of historical progress in liberalism, or economic ‘laws’ in Marxism). When the dichotomic dimension dominates, emancipation appears as a leap of faith from an inexplicable or irrational past (for example, religious messianism). Thus we are presented with the paradox: both dimensions are required if emancipation is to indicate a genuine break, one that is also the foundation of a new social order, yet each logically contradicts the other (Laclau, 1996, p. 6). But even if they are logically



incompatible, Laclau argues, both poles remain essential to emancipatory discourse; yet only if their opposition is made to mutually weaken the other. Like Vattimo, he agrees that no objective ground to the social can be discerned (most of his work has involved a critique of sociological objectivism, particularly in the Marxist tradition). There is no underlying structural principle of society that guarantees the rationality and universality of its refoundation. But – and here is where he begins to depart from Vattimo – if an objective ground is impossible, nevertheless the ‘figure’ of ground remains important at a *symbolic* level. Emancipatory discourses must signify a break that extends across society and makes ‘equivalences’ with a multiplicity of demands, otherwise they remain isolated particularities. This figure, in Laclau’s analysis, presents itself negatively, as the principle of an ‘absent fullness’ that imagines a future order via ‘universal’ goals, such as democracy, justice or equality, for example.

Of course, these universals cannot ever be fully achieved. With Vattimo, Laclau agrees that ‘conflicts of interpretation’ and relations of power cannot ever be eradicated. Only limited and partial forms of emancipation can be imagined if differences can never be finally reconciled. In the current age, emancipation cannot be conceived as a final, once-and-for-all act achieved by a privileged social agent. Instead, a radical democracy involves the temporary ‘hegemonization’ of diverse demands around certain universals, extending the diversity and range of emancipatory demands that may be encompassed in them. These universals are never exhausted by any one group or set of demands and will remain forever ‘provisional’ and ‘incomplete’ (Laclau, 1996, p. 16).

The outcome of Laclau’s argument is that emancipation is shot through with politics: it necessitates a contest over which principles are required, with whom and how they articulate, who they exclude and so forth. Above all, for Laclau, emancipatory politics engages a field of antagonism and conflict: defining universal principles in the quest for liberation entails drawing frontiers around ‘enemies’ and obstacles to liberation in order to produce a coherent political identity. The conflicts produced by such antagonisms are not secondary effects but are integral to hegemonic politics.

Laclau’s approach to emancipation is a useful counter-point to Vattimo’s. Both accept that late modernity is characterized by pluralization of social and political demands that cannot be absorbed without violence into a single emancipatory project. Again, for both, this opens up a distinctive kind of (potentially democratic) contest to define and temporarily unify these demands. However, Vattimo’s focus is less on the contest and more on the common disposition that nourishes it. This disposition, which Laclau describes by his term ‘dislocation’ – a destabilization of identity brought by increasing diversity (see Laclau, 1990, pp. 39–41) – is, for Vattimo, itself the source of an



ethical stance that can motivate the relinquishing of metaphysical absolutes in favour of dialogue. But for Laclau it is not the background experience of dislocation but rather the moment of antagonism with a generic 'other' – conceived as an obstacle to the realization of identity (for example, war, capitalism, injustice) – that gives coherence to political struggles, unifying them behind a 'frontier' that opposes what lies beyond it. For example, the Left has typically sought to unify various particular demands concerning poverty, health, and conditions of employment around antagonisms with capitalism or its representatives. The shared impossibility of self-identity is thus displaced onto an antagonistic other generating a contest that then discriminates between different demands for freedom, such as rights to welfare services over market freedoms. Thus for Laclau emancipation is fundamentally a political experience in which a fundamental difference is foregrounded, whereas for Vattimo it is an ethical one where a thin, common identity is foregrounded.

We should not press this distinction between Laclau and Vattimo too far. But Laclau's political reading of emancipation highlights blind spots in Vattimo's ethical account. In particular, nihilism cannot be treated as a neutral definition of the epoch that escapes the contest of interpretations. Despite acknowledging the potential for contest and disagreement, Vattimo tends to treat his view of nihilism as itself uncontentious, that is, as the source of an inclusive narrative from which a new postmodern sensibility can be harvested. But, as Laclau highlights, political discourses function by projecting particular dislocations as thematic of a wider sense of loss where greater freedom for some might be regarded as evidence of a general social 'decline' or even of disorder. Thus, for example, social diversity and the successes of feminism can be presented by the Christian Right as symptomatic of a loss of the 'true' meaning of the family and a proper sense of moral direction. Nihilism, as the dissolution of foundations, often plays directly into the hands of those who wish to *reinstall* metaphysically loaded concepts and values. Of course, Vattimo is not unaware of this reactive tendency in a nihilistic age, but his advocacy of an emancipatory orientation to nihilism is often presented as the only genuine option when, instead, it is only one potential response.

This raises the question as to whether Emancipatory Nihilism amounts to an ethical position designed primarily to justify the aspirations of the libertarian Left and progressive social movements, inclined as they are to seek a moderate balance of liberty with solidarity. Vattimo's own libertarian and democratic politics demonstrate his commitment to this constituency, and his hostility to Italy's currently ascendant right-wing indicates that he knows there are enemies to greater liberty out there. But, surely, as an account of Being in the current epoch, Emancipatory Nihilism is also intended to appeal beyond



the Left and other groups already comfortable with the critique of cultural norms and hierarchies? To do so, however, requires presenting nihilism not only as the defining epochal condition but, further, as a universally desirable condition such that it might transform opponents to radical freedom into its allies. Laclau's arguments imply that this can be achieved only by moving beyond a loose ethical narrative and adopting a more combative tone that emphasizes 'better' and 'worse' responses to nihilism.

The absence of a strong sense of 'the political' in Vattimo's nihilism, I am suggesting, renders the project of Emancipatory Nihilism uncertain as a potentially hegemonic discourse. If nihilism signifies a universal horizon, can we differentiate between different, possibly less or non-emancipatory, interpretations of it? If it is an ethic of the Left only, on what terms can its (metaphysically inclined) opponents (such as the Church, free market liberals, nationalists and so on) be brought into a common conversation? This is not to dismiss Vattimo's project altogether. Emancipatory Nihilism is certainly a powerful and challenging philosophical argument in tune with other European post-foundationalists of a libertarian persuasion. And, for all his emphasis on the political dimension, even Laclau is tempted from time to time to infer a general ethic of finitude.⁷ Indeed, it is precisely the lack of an elaborated ethics that some see as a fault in Laclau's work (see Critchley, 2004) and which Vattimo's arguments might help to remedy. But, perhaps like Vattimo's own political alignments, Emancipatory Nihilism, as it has been articulated so far, evades any sense of a stable political frontier beyond the general renunciation of metaphysics.

Conclusion

Vattimo's Emancipatory Nihilism responds affirmatively to the question of whether radical freedom can furnish a sustainable democratic politics. His claim, drawn from his readings of Nietzsche, Heidegger and Gadamer, is that the decline of foundational principles is the only opportunity there is for an inclusive narrative of emancipation. As I have argued, emancipatory freedom is best understood in the relatively modest, 'disclosive' sense of an adjustment to our finitude rather than a quest for personal or collective autonomy. This way, for Vattimo, our freedom to be other than we are translates into a sense of common destiny. Our ongoing release from metaphysical truths entails a hermeneutic imperative to expose ourselves to different interpretations and so resist the temptation to invoke 'absolute' certainties. Various social groups and movements seeking liberation are likely to acknowledge the virtues of this enterprise. But political theorists are also likely to regard Vattimo's



postmodern ethics as a rather too optimistic view that fails fully to grasp the possibilities for antagonism and conflict in a nihilistic age.

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Notes

- 1 Rorty's political outlook is well summarized in Rorty, 1989, pp. 44–69; 1999, pp. 229–239; John Gray's position is defended in Gray, 2000; and his chilling view of utopianism is presented in Gray, 2007.
- 2 On the differentiation of 'positive' and 'negative' freedom, see the classic essay in Berlin, 1969, pp. 118–172.
- 3 For Vattimo's general reading of Heidegger, see his introductory volume: Vattimo, 2005. Heidegger and Nietzsche are central figures in most of Vattimo's writings on other topics. See especially Vattimo, 1988a, 1993.
- 4 In *Beyond Interpretation*, Vattimo takes issue with Derrida's deconstructive reading of texts, describing them as a form of 'aestheticism' which exposes the contingency of truth-claims but fails to look beyond the text to an emergent form of Being characterized as 'multiplicity, temporality, mortality' (Vattimo, 1997, p. 92. See also pp. 12, 100–103).
- 5 As he argued in his interview with *Lotta Continua*, the term 'revolution' has more a 'symbolic value' than a genuine strategic purpose (Vattimo, 1984, pp. 17–18).
- 6 Vattimo was keen to indicate that his shift to the Left was not an acceptance of the revolutionary communist tradition: 'I use the slogan: real communism is dead, long live ideal communism ... we should perhaps invent the term "liberal communism"' (Vattimo, 2007a, p. 36).
- 7 See, for instance, Laclau's comments at the end of his essay on emancipation, in which he declares, 'We are today coming to terms with our own finitude and with the political possibilities that it opens. This is the point from which the potentially liberatory discourses of our postmodern age have to start. We can perhaps say that today we are at the end of emancipation and at the beginning of freedom' (Laclau, 1996, p. 18).

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